AI bookkeeper

A repeatable setup for the next property

Purpose: keep reliable books in Zoho, automate approved work and bring the owner only exceptions. Target: the prior month ready by the following 7th.

Tools and responsibilities

- **Zoho Books:** official entries, reports and bank/card feeds. Statements, leases and receipts supply independent evidence.
- **Mac mini + Node worker + SQLite:** periodic processing and durable posting/review history. Codex builds and verifies; it need not stay open for the enabled worker.
- **Private Google Drive:** shared context, evidence and current status, plus encrypted recovery backups. Credentials and the live database stay on the Mac.
- **Muse or another collector:** downloads and verifies records, asks batched questions and delivers alerts. Humans help at actual sign-in or permission blockers.
- **Optional DeepSeek reviewer:** proposes routine classifications within a $5 monthly budget per deployment. Owner decisions and posting controls remain separate.

Build and verify in this order

- **1. Interview and establish private records.** Read existing answers; confirm accounts, rent/deposits, property use, history, reporting basis and authority. Property-level books are the default.
- **2. Verify source records.** Inventory existing files; collect bank, card, mortgage/escrow, PM, receipts and relevant tax schedules. Prove opening balances and complete pilot-month coverage.
- **3. Set up Zoho and migrate once.** Map legacy Wave accounts; bring across only missing approved history or supported openings. Preserve filed-year records and check historical and current balances.
- **4. Prepare the worker.** Verify fit, isolated settings, actual-host access, structured inputs, cloud delivery and backup restoration. Test required adaptations.
- **5. Prove the books.** Inspect one completed month's entries, purposes and balances. Rerun unchanged inputs and prove no new entries; independently review the result.
- **6. Enable and observe.** Activate one approved schedule. Verify an unattended run, fresh cloud backup and actually delivered exception before calling it operational.

How a normal month and year work

- **Daily:** process approved rules and retain exceptions. Exact daily displayed balance agreement is not the business goal.
- **Days 1-3 of the next month:** collect remaining statements and receipts; batch the actual human access/questions needed.
- **Days 4-7:** reconcile the prior month and publish a concise close with remaining issues. Compare identical cutoffs; distinguish profit, operating cash and tenant funds.
- **Questions:** eligible routine proposals may apply provisionally after 72 hours, but remain revisitable. Silence never teaches a permanent rule; integrity, duplicate, capital and historical-repair holds remain.
- **Year-end:** owner/authorized agent posts approved annual adjustments once; verify current-year expense and next-year continuity. Deliver CPA-agreed reports and a one-page brief explaining allocations already applied.

Lessons that make the next build shorter

- One lead, shared dated context and one current remaining-work list prevent repeated setup and conflicting status.
- Source checks precede migration. Verified amounts, correct purposes and duplicate-free reruns matter more than a green test or a successful API response.
- Reuse the rental code without adding infrastructure. Cash-basis reports, extra account types and annual posting need explicit adaptations/procedures; funds need additional accounting design.